

Polar bear

Polar bears live and breed on the sea ice that floats in the Arctic Ocean. These fierce hunters are also strong swimmers and can stay in the freezing water for hours. Mother polar bears are protective of their cubs and will stay close by, watching over them as they play together on the ice.

Growing up

Cubs grow fast on seal fat and will stay with their mom for two to three years. But when they become independent, they usually live alone and come together only to mate.

Hunting on the ice

Spring is a good time for hunting. Plenty of seal pups have been born, and there is lots of sea ice, so polar bears can get close to their prey. Hungry mom can regain her strength—and show her cubs how to hunt and swim.

Leaving the den

The mother's milk is very high in fat. It helps the cubs grow quickly. They stay snug in the den for a few weeks until they are strong enough to follow their mother to the edge of the ice.

By early spring, the cubs are ready to crawl out of the den.

See also

Read about the emperor penguin (108–109)—and how it gives birth during the polar winter too, but at the other end of the world.

A polar bear's fur is see-through, and its skin is black! The bear looks white because it reflects light.